already in the city centre. Obviously, the Soviet artillery was ranging on the Reich Chancellery, the last refuge of the big Nazis.

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The following morning, 21 April, Soviet tanks sped towards the Berlin motorway ring road to cut off the Reich capital and sever supply routes. Amid this chaos, Honecker's construction crew began a hastily forced march to the prison at Plötzensee and loaded onto trucks destined for Görden, where the warders were 'noticeably more nervous' and uncertain.15

As the battle for Berlin raged on in all its bloody fury, the northern and eastern suburbs of Tegel and Reinickendorf were captured. Fighting erupted in Charlottenburg, Moabit and Schoeneberg and, by 25 April, Russian forces were swarming through the ruined capital as civilian defenders threw down their guns. 'Wilma D', a sixth-grade pupil from the 41st school in Prenzlauer Berg, felt the full horror of the onslaught when a so-called Stalin Organ struck her backyard: 'my mum was standing there with seven other women when the grenade hit. Her legs were ripped off.'16 At the Zoologischer Garten in central Berlin, the scene was apocalyptic after artillery shelling destroyed roofs and killed most of the animals.

Two days later, on 27 April, the area near Görden was awash with Soviet troops who later conducted a floor-by-floor release of prisoners. Honecker never forgot the enthusiasm with which he embraced the Russian soldiers. 'They came as liberators, as class brothers and friends, as pioneers of a new, better future for mankind!'17

In their last hours before liberty, some prisoners had planned to launch an attack on their captors, but many guards vanished, while others surrendered rather than fight. Amid emotional scenes, KPD inmates mustered for a planned foot march to the capital. Honecker, though, would have none of it. Late on the afternoon of 27 April, after snatching a little sleep, he undertook